EU Parliament reaches deal on competitiveness fund

送信者: POLITICO Pro Alert 受信日時: 2026-10-22 19:53

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EU Parliament reaches deal on competitiveness fund
By Aude van den Hove · Oct 22, 2026, 12:52 PM · View in your browser

BRUSSELS — The European Parliament’s negotiators reached a deal Thursday on the European Competitiveness Fund, a proposed €400 billion vehicle to boost industry, research and innovation under the EU’s next seven-year budget.

“We have found a solid agreement,” lead lawmaker Christian Ehler told POLITICO. He added that it represented “a strong signal” for the fund to remain at the centre of the EU’s next seven-year budget, while pushing back against Ireland’s suggestion to slash its budget by 12%. Ehler said the proposed cuts were disproportionate.

The Commission’s proposal for the ECF seeks to consolidate 14 existing programs covering everything from clean technologies and defense to digital innovation and biotechnology with an overall budget of some €400 billion, including €175 billion for Horizon Europe, the EU’s flagship research program.

Recent discussions have focused on the question of access to the fund’s defense money for partner countries outside the EU, while other issues such as the ECF’s relationship with Horizon Europe and its governance have also been tackled.

“The compromise includes proposals for a more coherent link between the ECF and Horizon, by removing the programming of Pillar II of Horizon from the ECF, and instead establishing clear pathways to turn research excellence into a competitive edge,” said Ehler, adding that research and innovation should not be subjugated to industrial policy.

The German center-right lawmaker also said Parliament did not want to “grant the Commission seamless and frictionless budgetary flexibility,” instead proposing a “flexibility reserve” making flexibility and opportunity costs visible.

The proposal will now go to a vote in the Parliament’s Industry, Research and Energy Committee — likely on Nov. 10 — which would pave the way for a plenary vote. Interinstitutional negotiations could then begin once EU countries find common ground on the last remaining issue: the treatment of associated countries under the defense window.

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